

Ten Meals and a Stocked Kitchen

Enough to stop deciding what's for dinner every single night.

You don't need a hundred recipes. You need **about ten things you can make without looking anything up**, and the ingredients already in the house.

That's the whole difference between cooking and ordering. Not skill — repertoire.

01 The pattern underneath all of it

Almost every simple dinner is the same four slots. Learn the shape and you can improvise forever without a recipe.

Something filling

+

Something with protein

+

Something green

+

Something with flavour

Rice, pasta, potatoes, bread, tortillas — plus eggs, chicken, beans, ground meat, cheese, tinned fish — plus whatever vegetable you have — plus sauce, spice, butter, lemon, soy, hot sauce. Swap any slot. It still works.

WHY THIS MATTERS MORE THAN THE RECIPES

A recipe tells you what to do once. The pattern tells you what to do when you're missing an ingredient, which is most nights. It's also what lets you shop without a meal plan and still eat.

Make each one three times and you'll stop needing to read it.

ONE**Pasta, properly**

Salt the water heavily — it should taste like the sea. Cook the pasta one minute less than the box says. Save a mug of the water before draining, then stir a splash into the sauce and pasta together in the pan.

That mug of starchy water is the whole trick. It turns sauce and pasta into one thing instead of two.

TWO**Eggs, three ways**

Scrambled: low heat, keep them moving, take them off while still slightly wet. Fried: medium, lid on for a minute. Omelette: beat, pour, tilt, fold when the top is nearly set.

Low and slow is the answer to almost every egg problem. High heat is why they go rubbery.

THREE**Sheet-pan chicken and vegetables**

Chop vegetables, add chicken thighs, coat everything in oil, salt and pepper. One tray, 200°C / 400°F, 30–35 minutes. Don't crowd the tray.

Thighs, not breasts — far harder to dry out. One tray means one thing to wash.

FOUR**Rice bowl**

Rice, plus whatever protein you have, plus a vegetable, plus a sauce. Fried egg on top makes almost any version better.

The most forgiving meal there is. It's designed for leftovers.

FIVE**Stir fry**

Pan as hot as you dare. Protein first, out. Hard vegetables, then soft. Protein back in, sauce last, thirty seconds. Serve on rice.

Everything chopped *before* you turn the heat on. There is no time once it starts.

SIX**Tacos or a burrito bowl**

Brown ground meat or warm a tin of black beans. Season generously. Tortillas or rice, plus cheese, salsa, whatever's in the fridge.

Season the meat more than feels right. Under-seasoning is why home cooking tastes flat.

SEVEN

Soup from a tin, upgraded

Tinned soup or stock, plus something you add: leftover chicken, a handful of pasta, frozen vegetables, a swirl of cream, a squeeze of lemon.

Lemon or vinegar at the end wakes up almost any soup that tastes dull.

EIGHT

Baked potato

Prick it, rub with oil and salt, 200°C / 400°F for an hour. Top with cheese, beans, tuna, chilli, whatever's there.

Almost zero effort, and it cooks while you do something else. Do two.

NINE

Grilled cheese and tomato soup

Butter the outside of the bread, not the pan. Medium-low heat, lid on, flip once. Patience is the whole recipe.

High heat burns the bread before the cheese melts. This is the only mistake available.

TEN

Breakfast for dinner

Eggs, toast, something fried, beans or tomatoes. Takes ten minutes and everyone is pleased about it.

The correct answer to a night when you can't face cooking but shouldn't order in.

If these are in the house, you can make something on a night you didn't plan for. That's the entire point of a stocked kitchen.

CUPBOARD — BUY ONCE, REPLACE WHEN OUT

- Cooking oil — olive and a neutral one
- Pasta and rice
- Tinned beans
- Soy sauce
- Garlic
- Dried herbs — oregano, chilli flakes
- Hot sauce
- Honey or sugar
- Salt and black pepper
- Tinned tomatoes
- Stock cubes or powder
- Vinegar — any kind
- Onions
- Paprika and cumin
- Peanut butter
- Flour

FRIDGE AND FREEZER

- Eggs
- Milk
- Lemons
- Frozen protein — chicken thighs, mince
- Mustard and mayonnaise
- Butter
- Cheese — something hard, something that melts
- Frozen vegetables — peas, spinach, mixed
- Bread — freeze half the loaf
- Something green that keeps: carrots, cabbage

FROZEN VEGETABLES ARE NOT A COMPROMISE

They're frozen within hours of picking, they don't rot in the drawer, and they cost less. Fresh is better for things you eat raw. For anything cooked, frozen is genuinely fine — and it's the difference between having a vegetable and not.

Shopping so the food gets eaten

- **Check the fridge before you go.** Two minutes, and it's what stops you buying a third jar of mustard.
- **Pick three or four meals** for the week — not seven. You'll eat out, or repeat, or not feel like it.
- **Buy perishables for two or three days**, not seven. Fresh food bought on Sunday for Friday is food you're throwing away.
- **Keep a running list** — on the fridge or your phone — and add things when you notice, not when you shop.
- **Don't shop hungry.** It's a cliché because it's true and it costs real money.

THE MISTAKE EVERYONE MAKES IN WEEK ONE

Aspirational shopping. You buy for the person who cooks four fresh meals a week, and then you're the person you actually are, and half of it rots. **Buy for the cook you are right now.** Grow the list once you're actually cooking.

Clean as you cook

This is what decides whether you cook again tomorrow.

- **Fill the sink with hot soapy water before you start.** Things go in as you finish with them.
- **Wash while things simmer.** There's always four minutes of standing around.
- **Wipe the counter while the pan's still hot.** Wet is ten seconds; dried is three minutes.
- **Deal with the pan before you sit down.** Soak it at minimum.
- **Aim to sit down to a clean kitchen.** It sounds fussy and it's the entire game.

THE LOOP THAT ENDS IN TAKEAWAY

Dirty kitchen → cooking feels like a chore → you order in → money gone and the kitchen is still dirty. It compounds fast. **The ten minutes after dinner is the cheapest place to break it.**

*Ten meals, a stocked pantry, and a clean kitchen.
That's cooking. Nobody needed to make it more
complicated than that.*